

Request for Information
United States Army DODX Heavy-Duty Railroad Flatcar
06 May 2026

General information. The U.S. Army Transportation Command (ARTRANS), in partnership with the Army Contracting Command-Detroit Arsenal (ACC-DTA), is issuing this Request for Information (RFI) as part of its market research to identify innovative solutions for recapitalizing its heavy-duty flatcar fleet. The Government intends to pursue this acquisition through a competitive Commercial Solutions Opening (CSO) process. Depending on the final acquisition strategy, this is anticipated to be a multi-phased approach where the Government will solicit solution briefs or formal proposals from industry, evaluate the submissions against its requirements, and invite select vendors to submit a full proposal for a Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR)-based contract, potential prototype or production contract award. The information gathered from this RFI is critical and will directly aid the Government in developing the final requirements and determining the optimal acquisition strategy for the forthcoming solicitation.

The Army's current heavy-duty flatcars, critical for deploying the 72-ton M1 Abrams Main Battle Tank and other heavy tracked vehicles (HTVs), faces mandatory, age-driven retirement beginning in 2031. This creates a potential near-term capability gap in strategic mobility and force projection. This Request for Information invites commercial railcar designers and manufacturers to propose modern, cost-effective, production-ready, and interchange-ready flatcar designs that meet the unique demands of military logistics, ensure future-readiness for vehicle weight growth, and maximize cargo flexibility. **Reference the announcement released in System for Award Management (SAM) for registration details via the following link: [Sam.gov](https://sam.gov).**

- 1.1. Intent.** Participation in this RFI is strictly voluntary, and responses provided shall be at no cost or obligation to the USG. This RFI is an important opportunity for industry to provide valuable feedback for consideration in acquisition planning and requirement development. The USG will use responses to this RFI solely for informational and planning purposes. Responses to this RFI are not considered contractual offers and cannot be accepted by the USG to form a binding contract or agreement. Additionally, no contracts or agreements will be awarded as a result of this announcement. The USG will not reimburse participants for any costs associated with responding to this RFI. Data submitted to the USG will not be returned and will be archived as part of the USG historical records. Participation in this survey, while important to USG acquisition planners, is neither mandatory nor a requisite for future participation by any contractor in this RFI or any similar RFI or RFP.
- 1.2. Clarification of this action.** Responses to this RFI will be used by the USG for informational and planning purposes only. Responses to this RFI are not considered to be contractual offers and cannot be accepted by the USG to form a binding contract or agreement nor will any contracts or agreements be awarded from this announcement. Information provided by the USG in regard to potential contracts or agreements, as presented in this RFI, are subject to change. Additionally, this inquiry does not bind the USG to solicit for or award any contracts or agreements. The USG will not reimburse participants for costs associated with responding to this RFI. Data submitted to the USG will not be returned and will remain archived as part of historic USG records. While important to USG acquisition planners, participation in this survey is not a requisite for future participation by any contractor in a future RFI or RFP.
- 1.3. Proprietary information.** The USG acknowledges its obligations under 18 U.S.C. § 1905 The Trade Secrets Act, to protect restricted information provided to the USG. Pursuant to this statute, the USG is willing to accept proprietary restrictions placed

upon data presented in response to this RFI and to protect such information from unauthorized disclosure subject to the following paragraphs.

- 1.3.1.** Proprietary data may be submitted in writing and/or transmitted electronically and must be clearly marked “PROPRIETARY” with additional markings designating where “PROPRIETARY PORTION BEGINS” and “PROPRIETARY PORTION ENDS”. Proprietary submissions shall be accompanied by explanatory text, so the USG is clearly notified regarding which data is proprietary, and which is not proprietary. Electronic submissions shall additionally have “PROPRIETARY” markings on both the cover sheet and the transmittal email as well as the beginning of each file submitted.
- 1.3.2.** Mark as “PROPRIETARY” only data which is truly restricted information and to which there is a legal property right.
- 1.3.3.** Do not mark as “PROPRIETARY” data which is already in the public domain or is already in possession of the USG or third parties on an unrestricted basis. Do not mark data which is available to the USG or to the public without restriction from another source.
- 1.4. No classified data.** Do not submit classified data at any time or in response to the RFI herein.
- 1.5. Disclaimer.** The USG is not responsible for the public disclosure of unmarked data received in response to this RFI. Accordingly, RFI respondents shall ensure that technical data provided in response to this RFI shall be appropriately marked, as described in paragraph 1.3 herein, to ensure proper USG handling of the data. Should the USG need to reproduce the protected data for distribution purposes between USG offices, all such data shall be reproduced with restrictive legends in place. The USG may use support contractors in reviewing responses. The USG will review responses that contain proprietary information without using support contractors consistent with the resources available. In cases where support contractors may be utilized for review of proprietary information, the USG will use best practices to maintain protection of the information.
- 1.6. RFI response deadline.** Responses to the RFI herein, shall be submitted electronically in Microsoft Windows 10 compatible software, by 1700 Eastern Time Zone on 05 June 2026.
- 1.7. RFI response submittal instructions.** Responses to the RFI herein, including any supporting information, are preferred to be submitted electronically to the email addresses shown below. Large files may also be sent electronically via Department of Defense (DoD) Secure Access File Exchange (SAFE) (<https://safe.apps.mil/>). The subject line or package must read “(Company Name) Response to DODX (specify series) RFI.” Please spell out acronyms in their first instance. Electronic file formats will be compatible with Microsoft Windows 10 compatible software.

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- 1.8 RFI response content instructions.** Please respond to all USG requirements in this RFI as completely, accurately and with as much detail as needed to effectively provide the information being requested. Estimations are acceptable in the response so long as they are identified as estimates. Supporting information includes descriptive language as well as objective numerically based data, schematics, specifications, test data or certifications, and any other information which clearly and accurately supports the answer provided. Please spell out all acronyms upon first use and provide a table of terminology and acronym definitions as part of the RFI response. Not applicable (N/A) responses to requested information shall be avoided to the maximum extent possible and accompany an explanation as to why the response is N/A. N/A responses will be considered by the USG as a negative response. Detailed submission instructions are located in Section 3.

2.0 Design concepts.

The U.S. Army Transportation Command (ARTRANS) is evaluating a range of flatcar design concepts to address the force deployment and strategic mobility needs of the Armed Forces. The following subsections detail the specific parameters, payload requirements, and operational criteria for distinct railcar configurations currently under consideration. Industry respondents are encouraged to evaluate their engineering and manufacturing capabilities against these requirements. Respondents may choose to submit a technical response and Rough Order of Magnitude (ROM) for a single design concept, or they may offer distinct solutions for multiple design concepts within their submission. Regardless of the specific concept(s) addressed, all proposed designs must utilize Association of American Railroads (AAR)-approved components, meet or exceed AAR Equipment Engineering Committee (EEC) and Open Top Loading Rules (OTLR) requirements and must comply with MIL-STD-810 rail impact test requirements. The design solution must be capable of achieving rapid approval for AAR EEC Free (optimal) or Controlled Interchange Classification based on design parameters with limited to no testing required. Restricted interchange classification will not be acceptable.

2.1 DODX 40000-SERIES 6-AXLE HEAVY-DUTY FLATCAR (CARRY 2x M1 ABRAMS ON SINGLE DECK)

ARTRANS, in conjunction with ACC requests industry information and capability statements regarding the replacement and modernization of the DODX 40000-series 6-axle heavy-duty flatcar. The Government is seeking production-ready solutions that meet current and future strategic mobility requirements while enabling rapid implementation into interchange service with minimal to no additional testing

ARTRANS seeks to replace and modernize the DODX 40000-series 6-axle heavy-duty flatcar to meet current and future operational requirements. The solution must replicate the dimensional measurements, design components, functionality, and minimum hauling capacity of the current DODX 40000-series while incorporating modern materials, manufacturing processes, and design improvements where applicable including reproduction of the 3-axle truck. The design must be capable of carrying two M1 Abrams tanks or other HTVs on a single deck.

Please reference Attachment DODX40 General U9060001 for more details.

Key performance requirements include:

- **Carrying Capacity:** A nominal capacity of at least 150 tons to accommodate potential vehicle weight growth, with a gross rail load not exceeding 65,750 pounds per axle.
- **Circus Loading Capability:** The design must support “circus style” loading and unloading using stationary end ramps and allow vehicles to traverse across the deck of like-railcars without damage to the railcar or equipment. Gap between decks of like-railcars shall not exceed 5-ft (with 4-ft optimum) and the maximum deck height shall not exceed 51-in above top of rail (with 48-in optimum).
- **Dimensional Standards:** The design must comply with AAR Plate B clearance standards and safely negotiate a minimum 180-ft radius curve.
- **Load Tie-Down Features:** The flatcar must include a minimum of four steel anchoring channels flush-mounted parallel along the entire length of the railcar, matching the configuration of the existing DODX 40000-series. Two additional steel anchoring channels (one along each edge) must be incorporated as allowed by design parameters. The design must include collapsible ISO pedestal mounts to carry three Twenty-foot Equivalent Unit (TEU) containers. The TEUs should sit flush next to each other with a maximum gap of 4-inches between the TEUs.
- **End of Car Cushioning:** The flatcar must include an AAR-approved end-of-car hydraulic cushioning unit with active draft protection.
- **Contract Timeline and Production Scope:** The initial contract award is anticipated in 2028, with a period of performance ranging from 1 to 6 years. A total production volume of around 500 railcars may be expected, with a minimum required production capability of 100 railcars per year. Production volumes may vary based on Army deployment requirements and fleet design combination/mix decisions.

2.2 DODX 41000-SERIES 4-AXLE HEAVY/WIDE FLATCAR (CARRY 1x M1 ABRAMS ON SINGLE DECK):

ARTRANS currently utilizes the DODX 41000-series flatcar to haul heavy or wide equipment. Unlike the 40000-series, the 41000-series is only capable of carrying a single 72-ton M1 tank or equivalent Heavy Tracked Vehicle.

As an alternative to replacing the DODX 40000-series design, ARTRANS seeks industry information to modernize the DODX 41000-series 4-axle heavy/wide flatcar to meet current and future operational requirements. The solution must replicate the dimensional measurements, design components, functionality, and hauling capacity of the current DODX 41000-series while incorporating modern materials, manufacturing processes, and design improvements where applicable. The design must be capable of carrying a single M1 Abrams tank or other HTVs. This railcar design will use all standard commercial flatcar design

components and will not require new or reproduced component production lines. The proposed design must be production ready with minimal to no additional testing required, enabling rapid implementation into interchange service.

Please reference Attachment DODX41 General CC-8-94-00-001-E for more details.

Key performance requirements include:

- **Carrying Capacity:** A nominal capacity of at least 90 tons to accommodate potential vehicle weight growth, with a gross rail load not exceeding 71,500 pounds per axle (286K GRL equivalent).
- **Circus Loading Capability:** The design must support “circus style” loading and unloading using stationary end ramps and allow vehicles to traverse across the deck of like-railcars without damage to the railcar or equipment. Gap between decks of like-railcars shall not exceed 5-ft (with 4-ft optimum) and the maximum deck height shall not exceed 51-in above top of rail (with 48-in optimum).
- **Dimensional Standards:** The design must comply with AAR Plate C clearance standards and safely negotiate a minimum 180-ft radius curve.
- **Load Tie-Down Features:** The flatcar must include a minimum of four steel anchoring channels flush-mounted parallel along the entire length of the railcar, matching the configuration of the existing DODX 41000-series. Two additional steel anchoring channels (one along each edge) must be incorporated as allowed by design parameters. The design must include collapsible ISO pedestal mounts to carry three TEUs. The TEUs should sit flush next to each other with a maximum gap of 4-inches between the TEUs.
- **End of Car Cushioning:** The flatcar must include an AAR-approved end-of-car hydraulic cushioning unit with active draft protection.
- **Contract Timeline and Production Scope:** The initial contract award is anticipated in 2028, with a period of performance ranging from 1 to 6 years. Production volumes may range up to approximately 1,200 railcars, with order quantities subject to change based on Army deployment requirements and fleet design combination/mix decisions. Production capability of 200 cars/year may be required.

2.3 DRAW-BAR HEAVY/WIDE FLATCAR (CARRY 1x M1 ABRAMS EA. ON TWO CONNECTED UNITS):

ARTRANS is also seeking industry information for a drawbar connected flatcar design concept capable of hauling two 72-ton M1 Abrams tanks, with one tank carried on each of two permanently connected flatcar decks. This double-unit flat car design should be treated as a single railcar and will use all standard commercial flatcar design components. It will not require new or reproduced component production lines. The design must be production-ready with minimal to no additional testing required, enabling rapid implementation into interchange service.

Key performance requirements include:

- **Carrying Capacity:** Each flatcar body must have a nominal capacity to carry one 72-ton heavy tracked vehicle, with maximum additional capacity possible to accommodate potential vehicle weight growth. The gross rail load must not exceed 65,750 pounds per axle (263K GRL equivalent).
- **Deck Width, Height and Length:** The design must have a minimum deck width of 10-ft 5-in (with 10-ft 8-in optimum) and the height must be between 48-in and 51-in (above top of rail). Individual decks should have a minimum deck length of at least 40-ft not to exceed 50-ft (43-ft to 45-ft optimal). Deck dimensions must be capable of securing a single M1 or M88 vehicle per MI-19 (Tiedown Instructions for Rail Movements).
- **Circus Loading Capability:** The design must support “circus style” loading and unloading using stationary end ramps and allow vehicles to traverse across the deck of like-railcars without damage to the railcar or equipment. Gap between the two connected decks and the gap between the decks of like-railcars shall not exceed 5-ft (with 4-ft optimum) and the maximum deck height shall not exceed 51-in above top of rail (with 48-in optimum).
- **Dimensional Standards:** The design must comply with AAR Plate B (optimum) or Plate C clearance standards and safely negotiate a minimum 180-ft radius curve.
- **Load Tie-Down Features:** Each flatcar deck must include a minimum of four steel anchoring channels flush-mounted parallel along the entire length of the railcar, matching the configuration of the existing DODX 40000- and 41000-series railcars. Two additional steel anchoring channels (one along each edge) must be incorporated as allowed by design parameters. The design must include collapsible ISO pedestal mounts to carry two TEUs per individual deck (four TEUs total across both connected decks). The TEUs should sit flush next to each other with a maximum gap of 4-inches between the TEUs.
- **End of Car Cushioning:** Each end of the railcar must include an AAR-approved end-of-car hydraulic cushioning unit with active draft protection. The two individual railcar bodies will be connected by a drawbar only.
- **Contract Timeline and Production Scope:** The initial contract award is anticipated in 2028, with a period of performance ranging from 1 to 6 years. A total production volume of around 500 railcars (with two connected flatcar decks considered a single railcar) may be expected for this design, with a minimum required production capability of 100 railcars per year. Production volumes may vary based on Army deployment requirements and fleet design combination/mix decisions.

2.4 OPEN DESIGN CONCEPT TO HAUL 2X 72-TON M1 ABRAMS MAIN BATTLE TANKS:

ARTRANS seeks industry information to open innovative flatcar design solutions to haul two heavy-tracked vehicles. Proposed designs may include single-unit flatcar designs capable of carrying two 72-ton M1 Abrams tanks or multi-unit flatcars with separate decks permanently connected by a drawbar or other mechanism capable of carrying at least one 72-ton M1 per unit. ARTRANS is open to concepts that leverage modern materials, manufacturing processes, and design improvements to meet current and future

operational requirements. The design must be production-ready with minimal to no additional testing required, enabling rapid implementation into interchange service.

Key performance requirements include:

- **Carrying Capacity:** Each flatcar unit must have a nominal capacity to carry one 72-ton M1 for a multi-unit design or two 72-ton M1s for a single unit design, with maximum additional capacity possible to accommodate potential vehicle weight growth. The gross rail load should optimally not exceed 65,750 pounds per axle (263K GRL equivalent), but 71,500 (286K GRL) pound axle capacity will also be considered to support maximum carrying capability.
- **Deck Width, Height and Length:** The design must have a minimum deck width of 10-ft 5-in (with 10-ft 8-in optimum) and the height must be between 48-in and 51-in above top of rail. Multi-unit designs must have individual unit deck length between 40-ft and 50-ft (43 to 45-ft optimal). Single unit designs must have a minimum deck length of 68-ft. Deck dimensions must be able to properly secure M1 and M88 vehicles per MI-19 (Tiedown Instructions for Rail Movements).
- **Circus Loading Capability:** The design must support “circus style” loading and unloading using stationary end ramps and allow vehicles to traverse across the deck of like-railcars without damage to the railcar or equipment. Gap between decks of like-railcars shall not exceed 5-ft (with 4-ft optimum).
- **Dimensional Standards:** The design must comply with AAR Plate B or Plate C clearance standards and safely negotiate a minimum 180-ft radius curve.
- **Load Tie-Down Features:** Each flatcar unit must include a minimum of four steel anchoring channels flush-mounted parallel along the entire length of the railcar, matching the configuration of the existing DODX 40000- and 41000-series railcars. Two additional steel anchoring channels (one along each edge) must be incorporated as allowed by design parameters. The design must include collapsible ISO pedestal mounts to carry at least two TEUs per multiple deck unit design or three TEUs for a single deck unit design. The TEUs should sit flush next to each other with a maximum gap of 4-inches between the TEUs.
- **Contract Timeline and Production Scope:** The initial contract award is anticipated in 2028, with a period of performance ranging from 1 to 6 years. Production volumes may vary based on Army deployment requirements and fleet design combination/mix decisions. A total production volume of around 500 railcars may be expected, with a minimum required production capability of 100 railcars per year.

3.0 Instructions for RFI response submissions:

3.1 Content and Format:

Request that responses include the information below. Individual proposal responses per each design concept shall not exceed five

(5) single-sided written pages using 12-point font or, alternatively, responses may take the form of briefing slides which shall not exceed fifteen (15) slides:

1. **Title Page:** Company name, size (# employees), title, date, point of contact name, e-mail address, phone, physical address, and identification of current Association of American Railroads (AAR) M-1003 Certification for Activity Code A20 (manufacturer of freight cars). Specifically identify the design concept for which the paper/brief is submitted for.
2. **Executive Summary:** Provide an executive summary of the solution which would satisfy the subject design concept and the company's existing and projected future production capability for said solution (e.g. maximum # of railcars produced per year), with an anticipated production start in 2028. If production "ramp up" time is needed per the design concept, please identify it.
3. **Design Concept:** Show and/or describe how the proposed solution satisfies the requirements of the design concept. Provide a concept design drawing(s) showing overall dimensions and general railcar arrangement. Describe any unique or novel aspects of the design and the proposed capabilities as it relates to the design concept. Identify whether the effort requires a pilot or demonstration railcar for testing and interchange approval purposes. And/or identify use of existing commercial railcar designs in current interchange (free or controlled) service. If development time or pilot/prototype is proposed, identify a suggested path to test the design to ensure it achieves necessary AAR interchange and Army transportability approvals prior to targeted full-service integration starting in FY30. Identify aspects of the proposal, to include software/design components, which may be considered proprietary.
4. **Price:** Provide a Rough Order of Magnitude (ROM) unit price and state your preferred payment terms. Base your pricing on a 2028 contract award and production start. Ensure the unit price includes the cost for the required number of DODX ½-in tiedown chain sets (16 chains per loaded Heavy Tracked Vehicle).

Volume Tiers: Provide ROM pricing for the following annual production volumes:

- Tier 1: 1 to 50 railcars per year
- Tier 2: 51 to 100 railcars per year
- Tier 3: 101 to 200 railcars per year
- Tier 4: More than 200 railcars per year.

NOTE: While the title page does not count against the page/slide limit, the executive summary, design concept, and price sections do.

3.2 Guidelines for Submission of Multiple and Distinct Offers

To assist the USG in gathering maximum insight and to foster a robust and competitive future Commercial Solutions Opening process, offerors are encouraged to submit proposals across any and all design concepts they deem appropriate. The submission of multiple proposals is permitted under the following conditions:

- **Multiple Design Concepts:** Offerors may submit one or more responses for all the different design concepts outlined in Section 2.

- **Single Design Concept:** An offeror may submit multiple proposal responses for the same design concept. Each proposal must, however, represent a separate and distinct design concept.

3.3 Detailed Description and Performance Metrics

All responses should be specific, data-driven, and adhere to the instructions provided in this RFI.
Your response should:

- **Be Specific and Factual:** Provide detailed descriptions of your proposed solutions, capabilities, and relevant performance metrics. Avoid subjective or opinion-based answers.
- **Incorporate Quantitative Data:** Whenever possible, use numerical data to support your response. This includes information such as dimensions, weights, payload capacity, technical specifications, and date ranges.
- **Reference Relevant Sections:** Ensure your responses are consistent with the submission instructions in Section 1.7 and 1.8, content and format requirements in Section 3.1, and the physical characteristics described for the specific design concepts (Section 2) you are addressing.
- **Provide Supporting Evidence:** For each requested piece of information, include a clear reference to any supporting documentation (e.g., schematics, test data, specifications) or an electronic link where the information can be verified.
- **Feedback on Requirements:** Please identify any requirements in the design concepts that you view as overly restrictive, cost-prohibitive, limit capability, likely to prevent successful interchange approvals, or likely to inhibit competition. If any, please explain your reasoning and recommend an alternative.

--END OF RFI THANK YOU--